

in the power sector with expertise in multiple areas. Going forward, Power Grid's consultancy and telecom (run under the brand name Powertel) businesses are the two key growth areas, he says. The challenge now is to diversify. "At one point... telecom, consultancy, etc. were like cherries on the cake. But we need to deepen that. We're now going to focus on our data centre business. That's why we've set up a data centre unit at Manesar and will look at scaling it up," Sreekant says. Power Grid also plans to improve its global footprint in the consultancy space. "We have a footprint in 21 countries. Our next step is to increase our engagement and look at global investments."

M. Taj Mukarrum, Power Grid's Director (Finance), has known Sreekant for the last 38 years. Both joined NTPC as trainees, with 58-year-old Sreekant staying on till 2016. "He was the youngest in a batch of 20-25 management trainees and is a gold medallist. Sreekant is a natural leader, backed by sheer hard work, sharp memory and analytical ability... [and] has always kept his head high with knowledge and a deep involvement in all issues relevant to his area of work," he says. Sreekant, Mukarrum says, has oodles of energy, keeps himself focussed and still appears fresh at the end of the day. His colleagues admire him for the way he managed the business despite the second wave of Covid-19 claiming at least 35 lives at Power Grid. "To the credit of my team, despite losing so many people, system availability and product execution didn't come down. Keeping them motivated was my biggest test as a leader," Sreekant says.

The next challenge, he says, will come from digital disruption. "In a large organisation the inertia is very high. The good thing is [that] traditional power businesses like smart metering, storage, transmission, etc. will continue to grow. But there will be additions. We have to enter these [new] spaces and do well. The willingness to change is essential," he says. "Digital disruption doesn't scare us. We want to harness it and turn it into productivity."

Sustaining growth, he feels, has been one of his key achievements. "There has always been a focus on addition of new transmission lines and capacity. Since 2012, Power Grid was doing almost ₹20,000 crore annually kind of capex. That kind of a growth cannot be sustained. Today, the competitiveness in this sector has increased. Everyone is now looking at tariff-based competitive bidding. One challenge is that the pie itself has reduced," he says. The second, he adds, is sharing that "pie with the private sector while our keeping leadership position intact". Sreekant calls himself a moderate risk taker. "I'm not risk averse but I will not play blind," he says.

Just like his colleagues, Swarnim Maheshwari, VP, Institutional Equities at Edelweiss Securities, too, holds Sreekant in high regard. "He doesn't dismiss any question and listens to everyone. Despite a financial background, he became the CMD of the world's third largest power transmission company—a testament to the fact that he has technically sound knowledge of the power sector," he says.

Power

K. Sreekant

Chairman and MD, Power Grid Corporation of India

Revenue from operations	FY21	37,665.65
	Q3 FY22	10,001.00
Profit before tax	FY21	14,626.07
	Q3 FY22	4,279.23
Profit after tax	FY21	11,935.78
	Q3 FY22	3,349.44
	RoE (%)	23.02
	Market Cap	1,49,030.55

- Standalone results; all figures in ₹ crore except RoE
- M-cap as of February 7
- Data Source: BSE, ACE Equity

Maheshwari calls Sreekant a solid leader with an inclusive approach. "This company stood out under his leadership [during the pandemic]. The environment under him is very fair and transparent... from an equity holder's perspective, the dividend payout is going up."

Sreekant's next big focus is clear: traditional transmission and expansion of the data centre business. Though Power Grid is a PSU, experts say in the last few years, it has shown a start-up-like fervour. "It is a PSU yet its business style is commercial. It can take on the competition, given its strong technical/financial capabilities. It... is a torchbearer for the entire industry," says Maheshwari.

But who inspires Sreekant? Everyone from ancient Sanskrit scholars to his gardener. "I always tell people: if you want motivation, go meet my gardener. He's a self-starter and never says no to a task. *Ho jayega* [it'll be done] is his response to everything. I think that's an incredible learning about the pursuit of excellence," he says. **BT**

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